

MIG-7

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-7

Age: 52

Gender: Male

Country of origin: Brazil

Host country: Portugal

Years in host country: 8

Occupation: Taxi Driver

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I moved to Portugal eight years ago after economic troubles in Brazil caused my small business to fail, wiping out years of work and leaving me searching for a way to start over at an age when starting over is far from easy. Portugal and Brazil share a language and a deep, tangled history, so Portugal seemed like a natural choice, a place where at least I would not be entirely lost. My wife has Portuguese ancestry, which helped considerably with our residency application and smoothed some of the bureaucratic path. In a strange way it felt like returning to a distant ancestral homeland I had never actually seen, and I arrived with a mixture of hope, apprehension, and the quiet grief of leaving the country of my birth behind.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being accepted as more than just 'the Brazilian,' being seen and treated as a neighbour, a fellow worker, and an individual with my own story rather than as a walking representative of a nationality. It shows itself when passengers in my taxi chat with me warmly and without condescension regardless of my accent, when I feel that I am genuinely part of this community rather than perpetually on its edge. Sharing a language certainly helps and removes one large barrier, but true belonging, I have learned, goes considerably deeper than words alone; it is about being regarded as an equal, as someone who has a legitimate place in the life of the country.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: There is a subtle but real xenophobia toward Brazilians here, which genuinely surprised me given how much the two countries share. Some Portuguese look down on us, associating Brazilians with unflattering stereotypes about being loud, or unserious, or somehow untrustworthy, and these assumptions colour how they treat us. I have had passengers make snide, dismissive remarks about my accent or my origins, as though being Brazilian were something slightly shameful. It caught me off guard, because I had genuinely expected more kinship and warmth given our common heritage and language; I had imagined arriving among distant cousins, and instead found that some regarded me as an unwelcome poor relation who had turned up uninvited.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: Ironically, sharing a language created unexpected challenges that I had not anticipated at all, because Portuguese as spoken in Portugal differs significantly from Brazilian Portuguese in vocabulary, pronunciation, and rhythm, leading to frequent misunderstandings that a completely foreign language would not have produced, since at least then no one would have expected me to understand effortlessly. Beyond the linguistic surprises, the bureaucracy was slow and frustrating, and the cost of living in Lisbon rose sharply during my years here, making it genuinely hard to get ahead financially despite working very long hours behind the wheel. Making ends meet, let alone saving anything, has been a constant struggle that has tested my patience and my optimism.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: As a taxi driver I interact with all kinds of people every single day, which gives me a broad and constantly refreshed view of how I am received. Most passengers are perfectly friendly and treat me decently, but a certain number turn noticeably cold or condescending the moment they hear my Brazilian accent and place where I am from. My fellow drivers, a real mix of Portuguese nationals and immigrants from various countries, are generally supportive and look out for one another. The camaraderie among those of us who work the streets, who share the same long hours and the same frustrations, tends to transcend nationality most of the time, and I value that solidarity.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I keep my Brazilian identity alive through my passion for football, through the samba and other music that reminds me of home, and through cooking feijoada and other dishes for my family on weekends. Over the years my Portuguese has adapted somewhat toward the local norms, out of practical necessity, and I have genuinely grown to love many Portuguese traditions, foods, and ways of life. I am proudly and unmistakably Brazilian, and I will never be anything else at my core, but I am increasingly at home in Portugal as well, straddling both cultures comfortably now in a way that felt impossible when I first arrived feeling like a stranger in a supposedly familiar land.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: Portuguese media sometimes portrays Brazilian immigrants through tired stereotypes, focusing disproportionately on crime when it involves a Brazilian, or portraying Brazilian women in a disrespectful and objectifying manner that reflects badly on all of us. This kind of coverage shapes how locals view us and reinforces the prejudices that some already hold. I wish the media would show the other, far more common reality: the hardworking Brazilians, the caregivers, the drivers like me, the labourers and shop workers who keep this country running quietly while simply seeking a better and more secure life for themselves and their families, doing honest work and asking only to be treated fairly.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: The integration support available to us was minimal, largely because the authorities seemed to assume that language would not be a barrier for Brazilians and that we would therefore simply assimilate on our own without any assistance. But cultural integration is about a great deal more than sharing a language, as I learned the hard way. Some community associations offered help and

connection, which I appreciated, but the official government programmes largely overlooked Portuguese-speaking migrants, wrongly assuming that we would blend in effortlessly. That mistaken assumption left many of us to fend entirely for ourselves in navigating a society that was more different from our own than anyone had expected.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My children, now teenagers, speak with distinctly Portuguese accents and feel quite thoroughly European, more at home here in many ways than they would now be in Brazil. They sometimes downplay or even reject their Brazilian side in an effort to fit in with their peers, which quietly saddens me, though I understand the impulse. But they are doing well in school and have access to opportunities that I could never have provided them back home, and for that I am deeply grateful. I encourage them, gently but persistently, to embrace both identities rather than abandoning their roots entirely, to be proud of where their family came from even as they build their lives here.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, even among peoples who share a language and a history as the Portuguese and Brazilians do, we need to directly challenge the subtle prejudices and unspoken class assumptions that people carry beneath the surface of apparent familiarity. Cultural exchange events that bring the two communities together in a spirit of celebration rather than suspicion certainly help. Portuguese and Brazilians alike should learn to celebrate our shared history and heritage while genuinely respecting our differences rather than looking down on them. In the end, familiarity and mutual respect, built up gradually through everyday interaction, are what dissolve these lingering tensions between us.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to eventually own my taxi licence outright rather than working under someone else's, and perhaps, if things go well, to buy a small home here so that my family has a place that is truly ours. I dream above all of my children succeeding in careers that were simply not accessible to them in Brazil, of watching them build stable and prosperous lives. And perhaps, in retirement, when the years of hard work are behind me, I imagine splitting my time between Portugal and Brazil, enjoying the best of both worlds and reconnecting with the homeland I left, after so many years of labour and adaptation.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice, drawn from my own surprises, is not to assume that sharing a language means you will find instant acceptance, because cultural differences and quiet prejudices still matter enormously and can catch you off guard precisely because you did not expect them. Work hard and conduct yourself honestly, letting your reputation and your character speak on your behalf over time. Stay connected to your roots and your heritage while genuinely respecting the local customs of your new home. And be patient, because even in a place that seems familiar on the surface, building a real and settled life takes years of steady effort and no small amount of resilience.